

UNIT IV

Who Got to Roar

The Roaring Twenties · 1920–1929



US.28

US.29

US.30

US.31

US.32

US.33

US.34

US.35

US.36

US.37

US.38

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

The 1920s are remembered as one long party — jazz, cars, radio, and easy money. But a decade can roar for some people while it slams the door on others. Who actually got to roar in the Twenties, who got shut out, and was a country changing this fast becoming freer — or just louder?

Turn on a radio for the first time. Hear a voice and a song filling your kitchen from a thousand miles away. Watch a Model T roll off a line every ninety seconds, cheap enough that your family might actually own one. That's the 1920s — the decade America learned to move fast, spend big, and all listen to the same thing at the same time. But hold on. The same decade that gave us jazz and the Grand Ole Opry also gave us the largest Ku Klux Klan in history, a law that put a Tennessee teacher on trial for teaching science, and an economy quietly building itself on borrowed money. This unit travels with four young people who lived four different Twenties: Ruth, who rides the Great Migration north into the Harlem Renaissance; Dot, who dives into the dazzling modern world of movies and credit; Vernon, a devout East Tennessee farm boy whose hometown of Dayton becomes the center of a national argument; and Frankie, the reporter you already know, chasing the whole story. Your job is to answer the question the decade never quite did: who got to roar — and who paid for the party?

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you live the decade through a migrant, a modern girl, a rural believer, and a reporter before you meet a single term.
- Multiple perspectives — the celebration and the backlash, the modern and the traditional, the included and the shut-out, each given a fair and dignified voice.
- Primary sources — Langston Hughes's poetry, the Grand Ole Opry's own airwaves, the Butler Act, the Volstead Act, and the era's photographs and cartoons.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- Two Tennessees at the center — the Grand Ole Opry and the Scopes Trial put Tennessee at the heart of both the decade's joy and its culture war.
- The Arc of the Union — plot the Twenties' climbs, setbacks, and mixed cases, including who the boom lifted and who it left behind.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Ruth, 17

Rural Tennessee →
Harlem, New York City



Dot, 18

A Northern industrial
city



Vernon, 16

Rhea County, East
Tennessee (near
Dayton)



Frankie, 29

New York → on
assignment across
the country

Spread 1 • US.28, US.33

Analyze the causes and effects of the Great Migration, and how it fed the Harlem Renaissance's celebration of Black identity.

🔊 Imagine leaving the only home you've ever known — not for a vacation, but because staying could get you killed. You pack one suitcase, board a northbound train, and step off into a city where, for the first time in your life, a sign doesn't tell you where you're allowed to sit. That train ride was real, and six million people took it. Some of them stepped off in a New York neighborhood that was about to explode with the most exciting art in America.

The C-130 tracks a northbound train from a Tennessee cotton field all the way to a Harlem sidewalk. Archive watches the city lights come up. 'People don't leave home for no reason,' she says. 'Every family on that train is running from something — and toward something. Watch what they build when they arrive.'



ERA-FRIEND

Ruth • the train north

Ruth is seventeen when her family joins the Great Migration — the vast movement of more than six million African Americans out of the rural South between about 1916 and 1970. She knows exactly why they're leaving: Jim Crow segregation, the constant threat of racial violence, no vote, and no future sharecropping someone else's land. Up North there are factory jobs that pay two or three times Southern wages, and cities where the rules, while far from fair, are at least different. The train ride is terrifying and thrilling. Ruth doesn't know yet that she's stepping into Harlem at the exact moment it becomes the capital of Black America.

GROUP

Harlem • a renaissance

What Ruth walks into is the Harlem Renaissance — a 1920s explosion of Black literature, art, and music that did something revolutionary: it celebrated Black identity, beauty, and pride out loud, on its own terms. In the clubs, Louis Armstrong's trumpet and Duke Ellington's orchestra reinvented American music. On the page, writers like Langston Hughes and Zora Neale Hurston put Black life at the center of American literature. It wasn't just entertainment. It was a people who had been told they were less announcing, in poetry and brass, that they were fully, beautifully American — and daring the country to disagree.

PRIMARY VOICE

Langston Hughes • 'I, too, am America'

One young poet said it plainest. In 'I, Too' (1926), Langston Hughes wrote as 'the darker brother' who is sent to eat in the kitchen when company comes — but who is growing strong, and who declares that tomorrow he'll be at the table, and nobody will dare send him away. 'I, too, am America,' the poem ends. It's not a protest sign; it's a quiet, unbreakable claim. Hughes takes the whole argument of this spread — that Black Americans belong fully to this country — and folds it into fourteen lines a teenager can memorize and never forget.

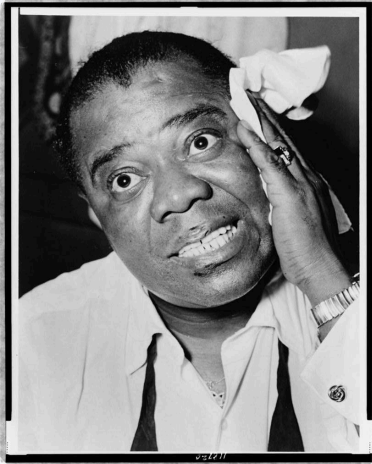


 An African American family of nine, dressed in coats and hats with their suitcases at their feet, photographed shortly after arriving in Chicago during the Great Migration, when hundreds of thousands of Black Americans moved from the rural South to northern cities.²⁸ on the Great Migration.

Family newly arrived in Chicago from the South. Photograph, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

 This is a real family, photographed just after arriving in Chicago from the South around 1920 — coats on, suitcases at their feet. Ask: what can you read in this picture about what they left, what they carried, and what they're hoping for? What can't a photograph tell you?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Portrait of Louis Armstrong, the African American jazz trumpeter and singer whose virtuosic playing helped define the Jazz Age and the Harlem Renaissance.³³ on the Harlem Renaissance.



Portrait of Langston Hughes, the African American poet and writer whose work gave voice to Black life and was central to the Harlem Renaissance.³³ on the Harlem Renaissance.



Portrait of Zora Neale Hurston, the African American author and folklorist whose fiction and ethnographic work were important contributions to the Harlem Renaissance.³³ on the Harlem Renaissance.

In plain words: Starting around 1916, more than six million African Americans left the rural South and moved to Northern and Western cities. They were escaping Jim Crow segregation and violence ('push' factors) and seeking better-paying factory jobs and more freedom ('pull' factors). This is the Great Migration. Many settled in Harlem, New York, which became the center of the Harlem Renaissance — a 1920s burst of Black writing, art, and music (Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, Louis Armstrong) that celebrated Black identity and changed American culture.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee was both a starting point and a source of the sound. Black Tennesseans joined the Migration north, and the music went with them: in Memphis, W.C. Handy — the 'Father of the Blues' — had turned the work songs and spirituals of the Mississippi Delta into published blues, and Beale Street became a cradle of the music that migrants carried into the clubs of Chicago, Harlem, and beyond. The Great Migration didn't just move people. It moved Tennessee's music into the heart of American culture.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Jim Crow denied Black Southerners safety, the vote, and opportunity.
- **Head out of the sand:** African American families who decided to leave, and Black newspapers like the Chicago Defender that urged them north.
- **Voice raised:** Migration itself as a mass act of protest — 'voting with their feet' — plus a cultural explosion that demanded to be seen and heard.
- **Government response:** Little immediate government action; the political power built in Northern cities would help fuel the later Civil Rights Movement.
- **Still unfinished:** Northern cities offered freedom and new forms of segregation and discrimination; the full promise was still decades away.

✓ **Check:** Explain the Great Migration using push and pull factors, then explain how it connected to the Harlem Renaissance. Use one piece of evidence (a source or figure) from the spread.

Show what you know:

- Write the letter Ruth sends back to a cousin in Tennessee after her first month in Harlem — the good and the hard.
 - Respond to Hughes's 'I, Too' with your own short 'I, too...' verse about belonging.
 - Map the Great Migration: three Southern origins, three Northern destinations, and one push and pull factor each.
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Spread 2 • US.30

Explain how radio spread American music nationwide, making Nashville the capital of country music and carrying the blues into the mainstream.

🔊 Your favorite song right now — how did you find it? A stream, an algorithm, a phone. Now erase all of that. In 1925 a brand-new machine did something that had never happened in human history: it let a kid on a Tennessee farm and a family in a Chicago apartment hear the exact same fiddle tune, live, at the exact same moment. Radio didn't just play music. It stitched a country together one song at a time — and it put a Tennessee city at the center of the map.

Archive parks the C-130 over Nashville on a Saturday night in 1925, antenna lights blinking. 'Listen,' she says, and pipes in a barn-dance fiddle crackling over the airwaves. 'That signal is reaching a hundred thousand living rooms. A brand-new kind of fame is being born, and it's got a Tennessee accent.'



ERA-FRIEND

Vernon • Saturday night on the radio

For Vernon, a sixteen-year-old on a hardscrabble farm in East Tennessee, the radio is a miracle bolted to the parlor wall. And the best night is Saturday, when Nashville's WSM broadcasts the program that will soon be called the Grand Ole Opry — string bands, fiddles, and mountain songs that sound like home. The Opry, launched in 1925, is turning Nashville into the capital of country music, and it's telling farm kids like Vernon that their music — rural, old-time, unfashionable — matters enough to put on the air. In a decade that keeps telling Vernon the future belongs to the city, the Opry says his world has a place in it too.

PRIMARY VOICE

Bessie Smith • the Empress of the Blues

The same radios and records carrying Vernon's fiddle tunes were carrying something else across the color line: the blues. Bessie Smith, the 'Empress of the Blues,' sold millions of records in the 1920s, her huge voice pouring out of Black Southern experience and into the American mainstream. The blues had roots in Tennessee — in Memphis, W.C. Handy had first put the twelve-bar blues into published sheet music. What Vernon and Ruth both need to see is that the two streams of American music, the country and the blues, were rising at the same moment, from the same new technology — and both were, at their core, Southern.



📷 Portrait of Bessie Smith, the African American blues singer known as the "Empress of the Blues," whose recordings sold millions in the 1920s and helped bring blues music into the cultural mainstream.³⁰ on the rise of blues music.

Bessie Smith, "Empress of the Blues. Photograph, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This is Bessie Smith, whose records sold in the millions in the 1920s. Ask: before radio and records, most people only heard music made by someone in the room. What changes about a country when millions of strangers can all love the same voice at once?

In plain words: In the 1920s, radio let people all over the country hear the same music at the same time for the first time. Nashville's WSM station started the Grand Ole Opry in 1925, which made Nashville the capital of country music. At the same time, the blues — with roots in Memphis and W.C. Handy — spread nationwide, and Bessie Smith, the 'Empress of the Blues,' sold millions of records. New technology carried both country and blues, two deeply Southern kinds of music, into the American mainstream.

● **Tennessee:** This whole spread is Tennessee. Nashville's WSM launched the Grand Ole Opry in 1925 and its powerful signal carried country music into living rooms across the nation, crowning Nashville 'Music City.' Two hundred miles west, Memphis and Beale Street had already made the city a home of the blues through W.C. Handy. One state, two of the most important sounds in American history — both broadcast to the world in the Roaring Twenties.

✓ **Check:** Explain how radio changed American music in the 1920s, and give one example each of how it spread country music and the blues. Why is Tennessee central to this story?

Show what you know:

- Make a 'one state, two sounds' poster mapping Nashville (Opry) and Memphis (blues) with a fact about each.
 - Write Vernon's diary entry the first Saturday he hears the Opry — why it matters to a farm kid.
 - Research one Opry or blues artist and record a 60-second 'why they mattered' clip.
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Spread 3 · US.29, US.31, US.32

Analyze how radio and film, new technologies (aviation, electricity), and Ford's assembly line created a modern mass-consumer society.

🔊 One man flies alone across an entire ocean, and by the time he lands, the whole planet already knows his name — because a new machine carried the news into millions of homes at once. Then picture a car rolling off a line every ninety seconds, cheap enough that a factory worker can buy one. The 1920s is the moment America becomes recognizably modern: connected, mobile, and moving faster than anyone had ever moved before.

Archive throttles the C-130 alongside a tiny silver monoplane over the Atlantic, then banks over a roaring auto factory. 'Two machines, one decade,' she says. 'One shrinks the ocean. One puts the country on wheels. Together they rewrite what an ordinary life looks like.'



ERA-FRIEND

Dot · the modern girl

Dot, eighteen and living in a Northern city, is riding the wave of the machine age with both hands up. Her family's new radio brings music, comedy, and news into the living room — part of the first true mass culture, where millions of people laugh at the same jokes and cheer the same heroes. When Charles Lindbergh flies solo across the Atlantic in 1927, Dot hears it on that radio and screams like everyone else, because celebrity is a brand-new kind of magic. Electricity now lights her apartment and runs new appliances that cut her mother's chores in half. Best of all, there's a Ford parked downstairs. Dot's world is faster, brighter, and louder than her grandmother could have dreamed.

INSTITUTION

Henry Ford · the line that changed everything

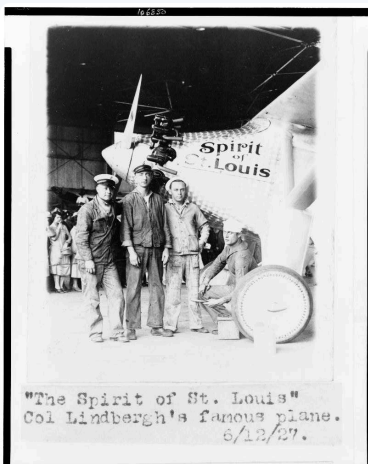
None of Dot's modern life is possible without a change on a factory floor in Detroit. Henry Ford's moving assembly line brought the work to the worker, so each person did one small task over and over — and it slashed the time to build a Model T and dropped the price until an ordinary family could afford a car. Ford even paid an eye-popping five dollars a day to keep workers on the grinding line. The result reshaped America: car ownership jumped from about 8 million to 23 million in the decade, and with it came highways, suburbs, gas stations, motels, and a brand-new feeling — that an ordinary person could just get in a car and go.



📷 Workers along the Ford Motor Company moving assembly line in 1913, where automobiles moved past stationary workers who each performed a single task. This mass-production method made the Model T affordable and transformed American industry,³² on Henry Ford and mass production. Ford Motor Company moving assembly line. Photograph, public domain (1910s-1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This is Ford's moving assembly line — the machine behind the machines. Ask: the line made cars cheap by having each worker do one tiny task, all day, forever. What does that trade — cheaper cars, more boring work — tell you about the price of mass production?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Charles Lindbergh's monoplane the "Spirit of St. Louis," which he flew solo across the Atlantic Ocean in May 1927. Lindbergh became an instant celebrity, his feat broadcast by radio and newsreel to a mass audience,²⁹ (mass culture and celebrity) and US.³¹ (new air travel).

In plain words: The 1920s made America modern. Radio and movies created the first 'mass culture' — millions of people enjoying the same entertainment and heroes, like aviator Charles Lindbergh, who flew solo across the Atlantic in 1927. Electricity and new appliances changed home life. And Henry Ford's assembly line made cars so cheap that ordinary families could own one, growing car ownership from 8 to 23 million and creating highways, suburbs, and new freedom to travel. Life got faster, more connected, and more mobile.

● **Tennessee:** The modern age rolled into Tennessee on radio waves and rubber tires. WSM's powerful signal carried the new mass culture deep into rural Tennessee, so a farm family far from any city could hear the same broadcast as New Yorkers. And as automobiles and new roads spread, Tennessee's isolated farms and small towns were pulled, for the first time, into the fast-moving consumer world of the decade.

✓ **Check:** Choose two of these — radio/film, aviation or electrification, or the automobile — and explain how each made American life more modern in the 1920s. Include one cost or trade-off.

Show what you know:

- Design a 1927 magazine ad for a Ford, a radio, or an electric appliance — then note what it promises and what it leaves out.
 - Write two 'a day in my life' entries: Dot's, and a worker's on Ford's assembly line.
 - Debate: did the automobile give Americans more freedom, or just more ways to spend money? Use evidence.
-

Spread 4 • US.34

Analyze the changing roles and status of women in the 1920s — flappers, the birth-control movement, and the limits that remained.

🔊 Cut your hair short. Wear what you want. Go out without asking permission. Get a job, spend your own money, and dance to music your grandmother finds scandalous. Sounds ordinary now — but in 1922 it was borderline rebellion, and it had a name: the flapper. The Twenties handed young women a set of freedoms their mothers never had. The catch? The country was happy to let them dance, and still not willing to pay them fairly.

Archive lands the crew outside a crowded dance hall thumping with jazz. 'Ten years ago, women couldn't even vote,' she says. 'They won that in a Tennessee statehouse in 1920. Now watch what a generation of young women does with a little bit of freedom — and watch where the walls still stand.'



ERA-FRIEND

Dot • the flapper's freedom

Dot bobs her hair, shortens her skirt, and feels the ground shift under her feet. The flapper isn't just a fashion — it's a young woman claiming space that Victorian rules kept locked. Dot has a job and her own paycheck; by 1930 about one in four workers is a woman. She goes to movies and dance halls without a chaperone. She feels, for the first time, like her life is hers to steer. Some of it is hype sold by advertisers, and Dot knows it. But some of it is real, hard-won room to breathe — the daughters of the suffrage generation testing just how far the new freedom will stretch.

PRIMARY VOICE

Margaret Sanger • a woman's choice

Behind the fashion, a harder fight was underway. Margaret Sanger led the era's controversial birth-control movement, arguing that a woman could not truly be free until she could decide for herself whether and when to become a mother. It was a radical, divisive claim in the 1920s — cheered by some as the key to women's independence, condemned by others as an attack on the family, and entangled, in Sanger's own case, with the era's troubling eugenics ideas. The crew handles it honestly: the core idea that women should control their own lives was central to the decade's argument about how free a woman was really allowed to be.

GROUP

The walls that stayed up

Here's the part the glamorous photos leave out. Even as women won new social freedoms, the country kept the economic doors mostly shut. Working women earned only about 60 percent of what men earned for the same work. Most were pushed into a narrow set of 'women's jobs,' and were expected to quit the moment they married. The vote was won, the hair was short, the jazz was loud — but the paycheck and the boardroom were still a man's world. The flapper could dance all night and still not be paid what she was worth in the morning.



📷 This 1922 photograph captures a flapper girl in stylish winter attire, embodying the Jazz Age's bold cultural shift toward women's fashion and social freedoms that defined the Roaring Twenties. A flapper girl. Photograph, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This is a flapper in 1922 — the decade's symbol of the 'new woman.' Ask: this image sells confidence and freedom. Whose freedom did it actually represent, and what does a single fashionable photograph hide about most women's real working lives?

In plain words: In the 1920s, young women called 'flappers' challenged old rules with new fashion, jobs, and independence — one year after women won the vote (clinched in Tennessee in 1920). By 1930, about one in four workers was a woman. Margaret Sanger led a controversial movement for birth control, arguing women should control their own lives. But big limits remained: women earned only about 60% of men's wages, faced job discrimination, and were expected to quit work when they married. New freedoms, real limits.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee women stepped into the Twenties with something brand-new: the vote. It was the Tennessee legislature that had cast the deciding vote to ratify the Nineteenth Amendment in the summer of 1920. Now newly enfranchised, Tennessee women — in Nashville, Memphis, and small towns alike — took a larger role in reform, public life, and the workforce, carrying the suffrage victory into the decade that followed.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Women had just won the vote but still faced deep social and economic inequality.
- **Head out of the sand:** Young 'new women' testing social limits, and reformers like Margaret Sanger pressing for control over their own lives.
- **Voice raised:** New fashions and behavior, workforce participation, and organized movements for birth control and women's rights.
- **Government response:** Social change outran legal and economic change; equal pay and workplace equality remained distant goals.
- **Still unfinished:** The gap between women's social freedom and economic equality is a fight that continues today.

✓ **Check:** Describe two ways women's lives changed in the 1920s and two limits that remained. Was the 'new woman' mostly real freedom or mostly hype? Defend your answer with evidence.

Show what you know:

- Make a two-column chart: 'New freedoms' vs. 'Old walls' for women in the 1920s.
 - Write a short scene where Dot argues with an older relative about bobbed hair and a job — steelman both sides.
 - Debate: was the flapper a real revolution in women's lives, or mostly an advertising image? Use evidence.
-

Spread 5 • US.35

Analyze the civil-liberties and civil-rights challenges of the 1920s — the Red Scare, the Klan's resurgence, the Tulsa massacre, and immigration restriction — and the resistance to them.

🔊 A country gets scared. Scared of radicals, scared of immigrants, scared of anyone who looks or prays or votes differently. And instead of talking itself down, it starts rounding people up, slamming its borders, and — in the worst moments — burning neighborhoods to the ground. The same decade that gave us jazz and freedom also produced the largest hate movement in American history. This is the Twenties with the lights turned up on its ugliest corner.

Archive sets the crew down on a Washington avenue as tens of thousands of hooded marchers file past. Nobody cheers. 'This is the same country, the same decade, as the Opry and the Harlem Renaissance,' she says quietly. 'Both are true at once. Look — and don't look away.'



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • reporting the backlash

Frankie has covered a lot, but this decade's fear tests him. It starts with the First Red Scare: in 1919–1920, terrified of communism, the government launches the Palmer Raids, arresting thousands of suspected radicals and deporting many with little regard for their rights. Then comes the revived Ku Klux Klan — not just in the South but nationwide, swelling to millions of members and targeting Black Americans, Catholics, Jews, and immigrants. In 1924 Congress passes the National Origins Act, slashing immigration from Southern and Eastern Europe and barring nearly all Asians. Frankie writes it down plainly, because someone has to: the land of the free spent this decade being very afraid of a lot of its own people.

GROUP

Tulsa, 1921 • a community destroyed

The fear turned deadly in Tulsa, Oklahoma. In 1921 a white mob attacked Greenwood, a thriving Black district so prosperous it was called 'Black Wall Street,' burning homes and businesses to the ground and killing an estimated hundreds of people. It was one of the worst episodes of racial violence in American history — and for decades it was left out of the textbooks. Ruth's family fled exactly this kind of terror when they left the South; Tulsa is proof that moving north or building success was no guarantee of safety. The crew refuses to let this be a footnote.

GROUP

The answer back • organizing for justice

But this is not a story of victims only — it's a story of resistance. Even in this decade of fear, Black Americans and their allies organized. The NAACP fought lynching and discrimination in the courts and the press. Ida B. Wells-Barnett, the Memphis journalist you met earlier, kept up her anti-lynching crusade. And Marcus Garvey built the largest Black mass movement of the era, the UNIA, preaching Black pride, self-reliance, and 'Africa for the Africans.' They didn't agree on strategy. But together they made sure that the decade's hatred was met, every step, by organized courage.



📷 Robed Ku Klux Klan members marching in a mass parade down Pennsylvania Avenue in Washington, D.C., on September 13, 1926. The 1920s saw a nationwide resurgence of the Klan, which targeted African Americans, immigrants, Catholics, and Jews,³⁵ on racial and ethnic tensions. Ku Klux Klan parade, Washington, D.C.. Photograph, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This is a Klan parade down Pennsylvania Avenue in Washington, D.C., in 1926 — tens of thousands marching openly in the capital. Ask: why would a hate group march in broad daylight in the nation's capital? What does that openness tell you about how mainstream this movement had become — and how does that change the story of the 'fun' Twenties?

In plain words: The 1920s had a dark side of fear and intolerance. The First Red Scare led to the Palmer Raids, arresting thousands of suspected radicals. A revived Ku Klux Klan grew to millions, targeting Black people, immigrants, Catholics, and Jews. In 1921 a white mob destroyed the prosperous Black Greenwood district in Tulsa. And the 1924 National Origins Act sharply cut immigration from Southern/Eastern Europe and barred most Asians. But people fought back: the NAACP, Ida B. Wells-Barnett, and Marcus Garvey's UNIA organized for justice and Black pride.

● **Tennessee:** The Klan's nationwide revival reached into Tennessee too, recruiting members and pushing its message of hostility toward Black Tennesseans, Catholics, Jews, and immigrants. Tennessee's own history holds both sides of this fight: it was home to the anti-lynching journalist Ida B. Wells before she was driven out of Memphis, and it felt the Klan's 1920s resurgence — the same clash between organized hatred and organized courage that played out across the country.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Fear of radicals, immigrants, and racial and religious minorities drove violence and discriminatory laws.
- **Head out of the sand:** Targeted communities and civil-rights organizers who documented and confronted the hatred.
- **Voice raised:** The NAACP, the Black press, Ida B. Wells-Barnett, and Marcus Garvey's mass movement.
- **Government response:** Government often enabled the harm (Palmer Raids, immigration quotas) rather than stopping it; justice for events like Tulsa came only generations later.
- **Still unfinished:** Confronting hate and protecting civil liberties in times of fear remains an ongoing struggle.

✓ **Check:** Identify three examples of intolerance or civil-liberties violations in the 1920s, then explain how Americans organized to resist. Why might these events have been left out of the 'Roaring Twenties' story for so long?

Show what you know:

- Create a 'both true at once' page pairing a joyful 1920s image with this spread's hard truth, with a caption explaining the tension.
 - Compare the strategies of the NAACP and Marcus Garvey in a short chart — goals, methods, appeal.
 - Write a respectful memorial paragraph for Greenwood/Tulsa that states the facts without sensationalizing.
-

Spread 6 • US.37

Analyze Prohibition — its goals, its unintended consequences (organized crime), and its ultimate failure and repeal.

💡 What happens when you make something illegal that millions of people refuse to stop wanting? You don't end it — you just hand the whole business to criminals. In 1920 America banned alcohol nationwide, hoping to build a cleaner, soberer country. Instead it built Al Capone. Prohibition is the decade's great cautionary tale about the gap between passing a law and changing what people actually do.

Archive drops the crew onto a rainy city street, past a locked door with a slot at eye level. 'Knock twice, say the password, and you're in a speakeasy,' she says. 'There are thousands of these in this city alone. Congress banned the drink. It did not ban the thirst. Watch the difference.'



ERA-FRIEND

Vernon • why good people wanted it

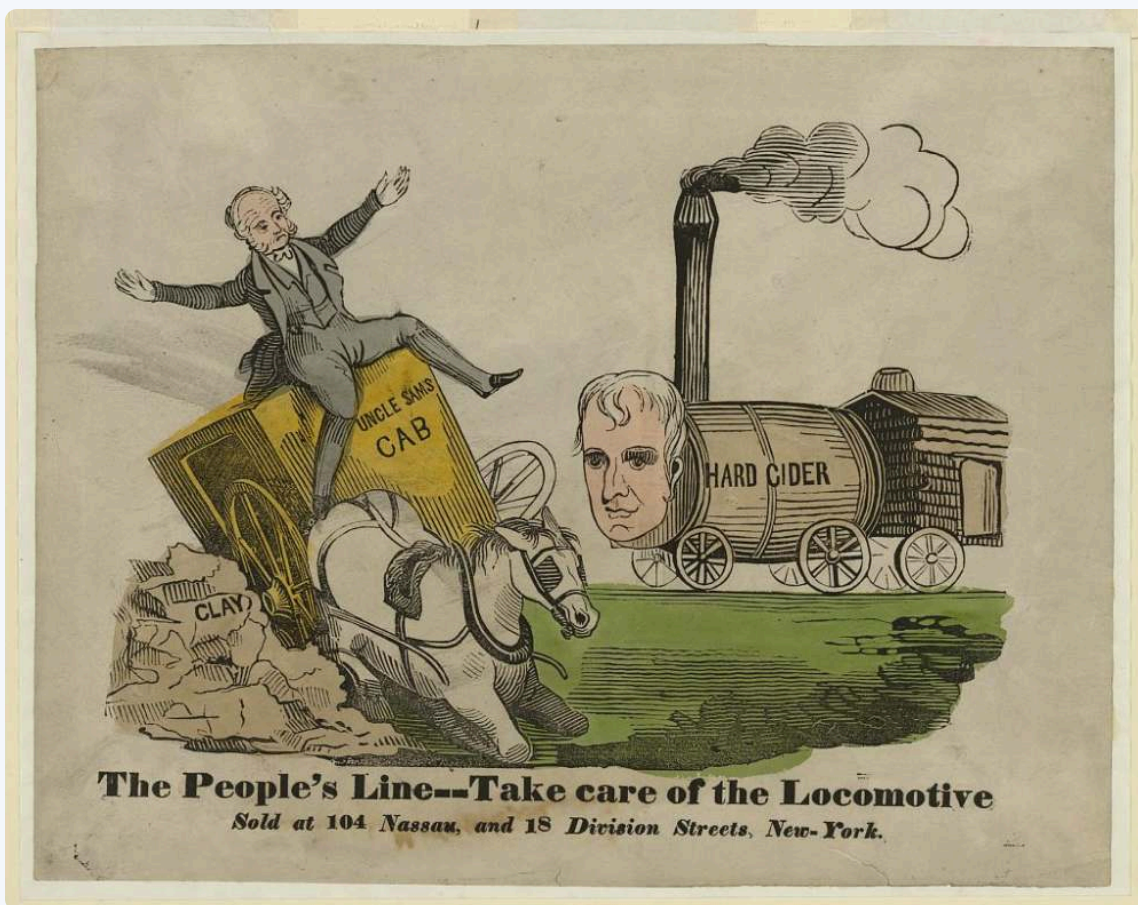
Before you laugh at Prohibition, meet Vernon, who supports it — and understand why. In his East Tennessee community, alcohol has wrecked families, drained paychecks, and put men in early graves, and the church-led temperance movement genuinely believes banning it will protect wives, children, and workers. When the 18th Amendment and the Volstead Act ban the making and selling of alcohol in 1920, Vernon sees it as a moral victory for ordinary families. His view matters: Prohibition wasn't a joke to the millions who backed it. It was a sincere, hopeful attempt to fix a real and painful problem.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the empire it built instead

Frankie covers the other end of the experiment, and it's a disaster. Because people still wanted to drink, a gigantic illegal industry sprang up overnight: bootleggers, smugglers, and tens of thousands of secret bars called speakeasies. Worse, the trade handed fortunes and power to organized crime — gangsters like Al Capone, who built a criminal empire worth tens of millions and enforced it with machine guns. The law meant to make America more moral instead made it more lawless. By 1933, the country admitted the experiment had failed and repealed Prohibition with the 21st Amendment — the only time an amendment has been undone.



📷 This 1919 political cartoon depicts a camel labeled 'National Prohibition Amendment' forcing its way into a U.S. tent, pushing out a 'Wets' opponent, symbolizing the unstoppable ratification of the 18th Amendment banning alcohol.³⁷ on Prohibition's constitutional impact.

A camel got his head in, and then -- !. Political cartoon, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This 1919 cartoon shows the 'National Prohibition Amendment' as a camel forcing its way into the U.S. tent, shoving out the 'Wets' (anti-Prohibition side). Ask: the cartoonist saw Prohibition as unstoppable in 1919. Fourteen years later it was repealed. What does that reversal teach you about passing a law versus changing a country?

In plain words: In 1920, the 18th Amendment and the Volstead Act banned making and selling alcohol nationwide. Supporters, like many church and temperance groups, sincerely believed it would reduce poverty and protect families. But because millions still wanted to drink, Prohibition created a huge illegal industry — bootlegging, speakeasies, and powerful organized crime bosses like Al Capone. The law was nearly impossible to enforce, and in 1933 the 21st Amendment repealed it — the only time a constitutional amendment has been undone.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee didn't wait for the nation on this one. The state had already outlawed the manufacture and sale of alcohol statewide by 1909 — more than a decade before national Prohibition — making Tennessee an early front line in the temperance fight. For Tennesseans like Vernon, the 1920 national ban wasn't a new experiment; it was the country finally catching up to a battle their state had been waging for years.

✓ **Check:** Explain why many Americans supported Prohibition, then explain its main unintended consequences and why it was repealed. What general lesson does Prohibition teach about laws?

Show what you know:

- Make a 'goal vs. result' flowchart for Prohibition: what supporters wanted vs. what actually happened.
 - Write two short letters to a 1925 newspaper — one from Vernon defending Prohibition, one from a critic — each making its best case.
 - Debate: was Prohibition a noble failure or a foolish mistake? Use its motives and its results as evidence.
-

Analyze the Scopes Trial as a dramatization of the clash between fundamentalism and modernism — staged in Dayton, Tennessee.

🔊 A small Tennessee town. A young teacher. A law that makes it a crime to teach where humans came from. In the summer of 1925, the whole country — reporters, radio, two of the most famous lawyers in America — descends on Dayton, Tennessee, to fight it out. It gets called the 'Trial of the Century,' and it isn't really about one teacher at all. It's about whether a fast-changing country still has room for an old, deep faith — and your hometown is the courtroom.

Archive brings the crew down onto a sweltering Dayton street packed with reporters, preachers, and lemonade stands. 'This is Vernon's world,' she says, 'and the whole country just showed up to argue about it on his front lawn. Two great Americans are about to face off — and neither one is a villain.'



ERA-FRIEND

Vernon • his faith on the witness stand

For Vernon, the Scopes Trial isn't a spectacle — it's personal. His neighbors passed Tennessee's Butler Act, a real 1925 state law making it illegal to teach in public schools 'any theory that denies the story of the Divine Creation of man as taught in the Bible.' To Vernon and many rural Tennesseans, the law protects something precious against a modern world that keeps telling them their faith is backward and their way of life is dying. When teacher John Scopes is charged with breaking it, Vernon feels the whole country arriving to laugh at people like him. He's not a fool and he's not a bigot. He's a believer watching his world put on trial.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie · the trial of the century

Frankie is in the Dayton press corps, and he's never seen anything like it. The trial pits William Jennings Bryan — three-time presidential candidate and hero of fundamentalist Christians — against Clarence Darrow, the nation's most famous defense attorney and a champion of modern science. It's carried by radio and splashed across front pages nationwide: the first great media-circus trial. Scopes is found guilty and fined, so the fundamentalists win the verdict. But in the newspapers, Darrow's sharp questioning makes Bryan's literalism look outdated to much of the country. Frankie sees the truth of it: nobody really 'won.' The trial just exposed a divide that runs right through America.



📷 Attorney Clarence Darrow, who defended teacher John Scopes at the 1925 Scopes "Monkey" Trial in Dayton, Tennessee, where the teaching of evolution was put on trial.³⁶ on the Scopes Trial. Clarence Darrow at the Scopes Trial, Dayton, Tennessee. Photograph, public domain (1910s–1920s). Source: History Hack Primary Source & Image Bank (Unit 4); original repository and archival identifier to be confirmed by a human reviewer at Schedule F sign-off.

💡 This is Clarence Darrow, who defended John Scopes in Dayton. The trial was one of the first to be broadcast by radio to the whole country. Ask: how does turning a trial into national entertainment change what it's really about? Does the show help the truth — or bury it?

In plain words: In 1925, Tennessee's Butler Act made it illegal to teach evolution in public schools. Teacher John Scopes was put on trial in Dayton, Tennessee, in a case that became a national media circus. Famous fundamentalist William Jennings Bryan argued for the law; famous attorney Clarence Darrow defended Scopes and modern science. Scopes was convicted (so the law's supporters won), but newspapers made fundamentalism look outdated to many. The trial dramatized a deep 1920s clash between religious tradition and a fast-modernizing world.

● **Tennessee:** Like the Grand Ole Opry, the Scopes Trial put Tennessee at the center of the nation — but this time in the middle of a culture war. It happened in Dayton, in Rhea County, under a Tennessee law, in a Tennessee courtroom. For one hot summer, this small East Tennessee town became the stage where America argued about science, faith, and how fast a country should change. Tennessee gave the Twenties both its favorite music and its defining debate.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A fast-modernizing culture collided with deeply held religious tradition over what schools could teach.
- **Head out of the sand:** Tennessee legislators who passed the Butler Act, and civil-liberties advocates (the ACLU) who recruited Scopes to challenge it.
- **Voice raised:** A deliberately staged test case, argued by national figures and broadcast to the whole country.
- **Government response:** The court upheld Scopes's conviction; the Butler Act stayed on Tennessee's books until 1967.
- **Still unfinished:** The tension between science, faith, and public education continues to surface in American classrooms and courts.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the Scopes Trial was about and why it mattered beyond one teacher. Represent both Bryan's and Darrow's positions fairly, then explain why historians say 'no one really won.'

Show what you know:

- Write two front pages about the verdict — one from a fundamentalist paper, one from a modernist paper — each fair to its side.
 - Stage a respectful 4-minute mini-debate on the Butler Act, then have both sides name the other's strongest point.
 - Explain in a short paragraph why 'the trial of the century' ended with no real winner.
-

Spread 8 • US.38

Analyze the economic weaknesses of the 1920s — easy credit, stock speculation, and inequality — that set up the Great Depression.

🔔 Buy it now, pay later. Put ten percent down and borrow the rest. Everyone's getting rich in the stock market, so throw your money in — prices only go up, right? If any of that sounds familiar, good: the 1920s invented the modern version of it. The decade roared partly because Americans were spending money they didn't have yet. And a party financed entirely on borrowed money has exactly one way to end.

Last stop in the Twenties. Archive hovers the C-130 over a glittering city skyline, ticker tape swirling below. 'Everything down there looks golden,' she says. 'Cars, radios, rising stocks. But watch how it's all being paid for. This is the last bright evening before a very long night.'



ERA-FRIEND

Dot • the magic of buy-now-pay-later

Dot has never felt richer, and she's barely paid for any of it. That's the secret engine of the boom: installment credit, the new 'buy now, pay later' system that financed most of the decade's cars and radios. Dot drives a car she's paying off monthly and listens to a radio she bought the same way. Consumerism — the idea that buying things is the path to the good life — is everywhere, pushed by the new mass advertising. Some of Dot's friends are even 'playing the market,' buying stocks with borrowed money because everyone swears prices will keep climbing. It feels like the good times will never stop. It feels, in fact, exactly like the moment before they do.

INSTITUTION

The cracks under the boom

Underneath the glitter, the foundation was rotten in three places. First, credit: Americans and businesses were deep in debt. Second, speculation: investors bought stocks 'on margin,' putting down as little as ten percent and borrowing the other ninety, betting prices would rise forever — so when they fell, the debts would come crashing down. Third, inequality: the decade's wealth pooled at the top while farmers and many workers barely shared in it, so there weren't enough solid buyers to keep the economy healthy. In 1929 the whole debt-built structure collapsed, triggering the Great Depression — the story that opens your next unit.

 **Primary source:** The 1920s boom rested on installment credit that financed most cars and radios, on stock speculation with mostly borrowed money ('on margin'), and on a belief that prices would rise forever — while deep inequality and farm distress went unaddressed, until the debt-driven economy collapsed in 1929.

 Three weaknesses — too much debt, too much speculation, too much inequality — were hiding under a glittering boom. Which of the three do you think was most dangerous, and why? Do you see any of them around you today?

In plain words: The 1920s boom was built on shaky ground. People bought most cars and radios on installment credit ('buy now, pay later'), going into debt. Investors bought stocks 'on margin' — putting down about 10% and borrowing the rest — betting prices would always rise. And wealth was very unequal: the rich got much richer while farmers and many workers were left out. This mix of debt, speculation, and inequality was dangerous, and in 1929 the economy collapsed, starting the Great Depression (your next unit).

 **Tennessee:** For much of Tennessee, the 1920s never really roared at all. While cities chased the boom, Tennessee's farmers were already struggling: crop prices had fallen after World War I, and rural incomes lagged far behind. Much of agricultural Tennessee was living in hardship years before the 1929 crash — a reminder that the decade's prosperity was never shared as widely as the glittering headlines claimed.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A boom financed by debt, speculation, and deep inequality was economically unsustainable.
- **Head out of the sand:** A few economists and struggling farmers who saw that the prosperity wasn't real or shared.
- **Voice raised:** Largely drowned out by optimism, advertising, and rising stock prices during the boom.
- **Government response:** Little regulation of credit or the stock market in the 1920s; major reforms came only after the 1929 crash, in the New Deal.
- **Still unfinished:** How to keep debt, speculation, and inequality from destabilizing the economy is a question every generation faces again.

✓ **Check:** Explain three economic weaknesses of the 1920s (credit, speculation, inequality) and how each helped set up the Great Depression. Which do you think was most dangerous, and why?

Show what you know:

- Draw the 1920s economy as a glittering building with three cracks in the foundation — label credit, speculation, and inequality.

- Write Dot's optimistic 1928 journal entry, then a note-to-self she might add reading it a year later.
- Debate: who was most responsible for the fragile economy — consumers, investors, or the government? Use evidence.

Toward a more perfect union

The Twenties are the trickiest decade yet for the 'more perfect union' question, because progress and backlash happen at the exact same time. The Great Migration and the Harlem Renaissance expand Black freedom and American culture — while the Klan swells to millions and Tulsa burns. Women win new freedoms — while a fearful country slams its doors on immigrants and puts a science teacher on trial. Watch the decade refuse to move in one direction. It roars forward and lurches backward at once, and the honest question isn't 'was it good or bad' — it's 'for whom, and at what cost?'

Closing question: The 1920s advanced some Americans and set others back — often in the very same year. Pick two events from this unit that pulled the country in opposite directions, and use them to argue whether the decade, on balance, moved the United States closer to its founding promise or further from it. Cite the unit. There's no answer key — make the case.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1920	Prohibition begins (18th Amendment)	A nationwide ban on alcohol aims to build a soberer country and instead fuels organized crime.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1921	Tulsa Race Massacre	A white mob destroys 'Black Wall Street,' killing an estimated hundreds and erasing a thriving community.	
1924	National Origins Act restricts immigration	Congress slashes immigration to favor a 'Nordic' racial character.	
1925	The Great Migration and Harlem Renaissance	Millions move north and Harlem becomes the capital of a Black cultural renaissance.	
1925	The Grand Ole Opry puts Nashville on the map	WSM's broadcast makes Nashville the capital of country music.	
1925	The Scopes Trial	Dayton, Tennessee hosts the decade's defining clash of tradition and modern science.	
1929	The credit boom crests	A glittering economy built on debt and inequality stands on the edge of the 1929 crash.	